Property of the Rebel Librarian

By Allison Varnes

ANNOUNCEMENT: **(Pg 59)** Effective immediately, Dogwood School Libraries will no longer house texts that contain profanity, drugs, violence, rock/rap music, witchcraft, drinking, smoking, or rebellion of any kind. They are hereby banned for unsupervised distribution. Students in possession of unapproved texts will face disciplinary action. Teachers in violation of this resolution will be terminated.

JUNE: **(Pg 58)** Since when does this school get so worked up about ***books***? **(Pg 59-60)** I'm going to be sick. I mean, who thought books would be cause for punishment? **(Pg 2-4)** I walk home from school *(June opens the door to her house and is confronted by her father)*

DAD: *(holding up a book)* Would you care to explain this?

JUNE: *(shrugging)* Um, it's a book?

DAD: *(disapprovingly)* Yes, *The Makings of a Witch*. One that we don't approve of. What concerns me more than anything is that it's from the Dogwood Middle library, of all places.

JUNE: *(to audience)* I can't watch TV or use the family computer without someone looking over my shoulder, but books have always been safe. *(to Dad)* Dad, if you'd just . .

DAD: No. This sort of thing won't happen again. You're grounded. No TV. No phone. No internet.

JUNE: What? **(Pg 8)** Being grounded for reading? That's a new one.

INTRODUCTION

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JUNE: **(Pg 30)** I haul my bags up to my room. *(she reacts with shock)* The bookshelf in the corner. It's empty. Every. Single. Book. Gone. *(racing downstairs)* What did you do with my books? *(Mom and Dad are reading her books)*

DAD: They're in safekeeping until we can make sure they're quality reading material. You

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will request books through us. If we have read a book and approve, we will release it to you.

JUNE: ***What?*** You can't be serious*!* *(June exits in huff)*

MOM: **(Pg 33)** I never dreamed we'd need to monitor kids' books. The look on her face. Our child hates us.

JUNE: This doesn't make sense. Nothing makes sense.

DAD: Our house, our rules. She'll get over it.

*******Scene – The Next Day at School*******

JUNE: **(Pg 56-57)** [The next day when I get to school] two moving trucks are parked in the pickup/drop-off circle. I wander off to the library. CLOSED FOR INVENTORY – and the door is locked. I'm about to turn away when the door creaks open, revealing a heaping cartload of books behind it. I hold the door while two older men wheel the cart into the hallway. Then I slip inside. The space is almost unrecognizable. Huge gaps linger on the shelves where large quantities of books used to be. Dad! What are you doing?

DAD: It's called a book extraction. It's necessary for quality control.

JUNE: **(Pg 3)** Dad is president of the PTSA, and he keeps his thumb on everything at Dogwood Middle. **(Pg 59)** ***Now*** I'm going to be sick. Just like that, I can't read a book at home or in the library. **(Pg 70)** I set off down the hall. *(she gazes at the walls)* New posters with phrases like COMMUNITY STRONG, PROTECT OUR CHILDREN, and STUDENTS FOR A MORAL FUTURE. It's signed by the Student Club for Appropriate Reading. SCAR *(groans)* **(Pg 121)** There's a picture of a homeless kid on a street corner smoking and drinking beer. Below it, it says DO YOU KNOW WHAT YOUR KIDS ARE READING? Who came up with this? There isn't even a book in the picture. *(she rips it down, wads it up)*

*******Scene – The Next Day *******

JUNE: **(Pg 54-55)** [Walking to school] the stop sign looms ahead. Except this time, I don't go where I always go. I turn left onto Maple Lane – the long way to school. Midway down the street, balanced on a tall wooden post, right by the curb is some sort of dollhouse. I've never seen anything like it. Below its top two windows, a glass door protects books on the

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other side. LITTLE FREE LIBRARY is engraved in a metal plate at the top. I feel like I just found a wad of cash, but better. **(Pg 269-270)** *Roll of Thunder, Hear My Cry* by Mildred D. Taylor, *The Lightning Thief* by Rick Riordan, *Diary of a Wimpy Kid* by Jeff Kinney, *Because of Winn-Dixie* by Kate DiCamillo, and the first Harry Potter book! *(she stuffs the books in her bookbag excitedly)*

ANNOUNCEMENT: (Pg 59) *(echoing)* Students in possession of unapproved texts will face disciplinary action.

JUNE: (Pg 88) But what if nothing is found in my possession? Rule #1: Don't get caught. **(Pg 93)** I have to wait until lunch to visit my locker. **(Pg 69-70)** [When] I slam my locker shut, the impact pops open the locker next to mine – candy wrappers and a few wadded-up balls of paper – nothing else. **(Pg 90)** And then I stop. [The perfect place for] a library! **(Pg 94)** *(she glances down the hall, clears the debris from the locker and transfers the contraband books from her bookbag into the empty locker)* One book can change everything. And I know where I can get more! *(she pulls a notebook from her bookbag and a black sharpie she writes)* **(Pg 98) PROPERTY OF THE REBEL LIBRARIAN** *(she stands up taller with confidence)* **(Pg 90)** Rule #1: Don't get caught. I mean it. Rule #2: Don't squeal. You just found this book. I had nothing to do with it. Rule #3: Give it back to me when you're done. **(Pg 97)** I'm going to use code names to keep track of everything. You know, just in case. *(she removes the combination lock from her locker and puts it on the new library locker)* **(Pg 103)** Locker 319 is secure!

****** A few weeks later******

JUNE: (Pg 269-270) *Bridge to Terabithia. . .The Outsiders. . .Matilda. . .Number the Stars. . . Coraline*. **(Pg 119)** Everywhere I look, kids line the hallways with oversized textbooks in their laps. Lunchtime, after school, their sneakers dangle off sidewalk benches. I don't have to look to see what they're doing I already know. Reading! And Dan Fuller, the most popular guy in school, high-fives me in the lobby. *(air high-five and happy dance)* This is no longer the same Dogwood Middle. It's an alternate reality where reading is the coolest thing you can do and I, June Harper, am the leader of the cool kids – of the rebellion.

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6th Grader: (Pg 129-130) *(in a whisper)* Hey, June? Do you have any Captain Underpants books? It's not for me. My little brother loves those books, but his school said they weren't good for kids.

JUNE: You're kidding, right. What's so wrong with a superhero saving the day in his underwear? It's not going to make kids refuse to put on pants or anything. What did the school think is wrong with them?

6th Grader: They said they were offensive and couldn't believe something with ***underpants*** in the title was in the school library.

JUNE: Oh no, not underpants! I do declare, what happened to decency?

******* At June's Home******

MOM: (Pg 141-143) Honey! Come down here a sec! We thought it was time we return some things to you.

JUNE: *(excited)* My books? They're all here?

DAD: More or less. It took us forever to read them all, but we finally did it.

JUNE: I have to take them an armload at a time. Ten of them, actually. Surrounded by my collection I sift through the piles. Old Yeller first. One of the pages toward the end feels thicker than the others. A white index card has been glued over the existing page. Travis is supposed to pick up his shotgun here, but instead it reads "And then Old Yeller was cured of rabies and lived happily ever after. That's it. The rest of the pages have been ripped from the spine. *(her jaw drops and she reaches for another book)* Diary of a Wimpy Kid -- Card stock glued over the fart jokes. The same edits are in my other books. Someone took great care to cut out tiny black rectangles and past them over certain words. This is exactly what Locker 319 exists!

******* At school******

JUNE: (Pg 195-196) The last thing I want to see when it's pouring raining and freezing is a line of students waiting to get into the building *(to another student)* Is there a reason we're standing out here?

STUDENT: Some kind of random search. It's probably about books.

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JUNE: *(nonchalantly)* Yeah. I heard books have been a big problem lately. **(Pg 199-200)** *(to audience)* The line leads to a table staffed by two security officers.

OFFICER: Bags down first, ladies. One at a time.

JUNE: A trash bin overflows with novels. My novels. Mr. Beeler, the principal, stands with his arms crossed, his eyes growing bigger with each book added to the pile. They found what they were looking for.

******* AFTER SCHOOL ASSEMBLY******

MR. BEELER: **(Pg 203)** There will be an emergency PTSA meeting Immediately following 6th period today. **(Pg 206)** We will begin promptly at 3:45. **(Pg 209 – 210)** As many of you have heard, we collected two hundred forty-two novels from the student body this morning. This isn't an isolated case of one or two books. This is a – a movement that has gripped out students. All lockers are being searched by the safety committee at this very moment.

JUNE: *(covering her smile and faking a yawn)(to audience)* They'll have a field day with Locker 319. No one has any ties at all to the locker. Not even me. Even if the notebook turns up, so what? Our names aren't in it.

MR. HAWKINS: **(Pg 212)** *(rushing in from the back of the auditorium)* We found it! *(he whispers frantically to Mr. Beeler and hands him a green notebook)*

MR. BEELER: Parents. It appears we have our answer. Locker 319. Unfortunately, there is no registered owner of this locker, which makes the offense even more serious. **(Pg 214-215)** I had hoped for the name of the person responsible for this. I don't see one actual student name in this entire book. It's one thing to run an illegal library on public property. But to write this on the cover? *(He holds up the green notebook)* PROPERTY OF THE REBEL LIBRARIAN

JUNE: *(looking at the notebook with her best bored expression)* There will be no confession tonight. Rule #1: Don't get caught.

MOM: *(stiffens and looks over at June, she speaks loudly)* Alma June Harper. How could you!

JUNE: *(aghast)* My handwriting!

*******Scene*******

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MOIRA ROBERTS: **(Pg 217)** Hi, I'm Moira Roberts, and this is the news at six. Tensions are running high today in the halls of Dogwood Middle. Classic literature was confiscated on the basis that it was not morally sound for young people. But they couldn't collect all of it. What school officials did not anticipate is that students would find a way to fight back. Not everyone is in agreement with the limits put on student freedom. But will the school board listen? Find out tomorrow night when I report live at Six. I'm Moira Roberts, and this is your Dogwood.

*****Scene*****

JUNE: **(Pg 216)** Suspension. **(Pg 220-221)** And the school board is holding an emergency session to deal with everything. My parents have arranged for me to publicly apologize. ***I'm not sorry. I didn't commit a crime. I opened a library!***

MOM: *(firmly)* What you did was wrong, and when you're wrong, you apologize. End of discussion. *(Cut to school board meeting)*

SCHOOL BOARD CHAIR: **(Pg 237)** **Alma June Harper . . . You have five minutes** *(June steps to the mic)*

JUNE: **(Pg 238-240)** Adults are always saying how we need to be responsible citizens, but how can we even learn what that means if you put the library on lockdown. I thought about that. And when I found a book I wanted to read, I read it. Then other people asked to read it, so I said yes. It got bigger. Before I knew it, I had dozens of books and an empty locker to put them in. And you know what? Everyone started reading. I've never seen more students read at school in my life. All because you said we couldn't. Are you going to keep punishing the whole school because we thought outside the box you tried to put us in. Will you do it in front of the entire nation? They're watching. I'm not some troubled kid trying to destroy the community. I am outraged. I am censorship gone wrong. *(she takes a deep breath, squares her shoulders, looks directly into the cameras)* **(Pg 246)** I believe in the freedom to read. Most people around here would call that rebellion, so I thought I'd beat them to the punch. Don't tell me what to read. **(Pg 240)** I am the Rebel Librarian.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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